mealtimes, Rajen shifts the books and papers to one side, making just enough space for Ratan's plate and the serving dishes.

The flooring is made of modern granite stone-coloured tiles. There is a lift to go to the other floors which Ratan uses more frequently of late. The terrace has a swimming pool overlooking the sea. The building also has a mezzanine floor that houses a library.

The parking space in front of Halekai is reserved for important guests or for Ratan's car when he has to go out. At times, one could spot a Jaguar, parked next to a Nano. Below the house is a basement garage for Ratan's favourite cars. In it, he has some of his favourite American muscle cars, some with powerful V-12 engines. It is this floor that betrays his wealthy background.

Ratan's lifestyle intrigues those who have had the privilege of visiting him. One would assume that he has a retinue of liveried butlers and cooks to pander to all his culinary whims and fancies. Every meal of his must consist of the finest dishes made by the best of the Taj's chefs. Nothing could be further from the truth.

Rajen is his cook, who also doubles up as a butler. He has been with Ratan since 1995. He is informally dressed and can on occasion be spotted in shorts and a Cornell alumni T-shirt. Rajen and Ratan are friends. Saturdays and Sundays are the days when Ratan has his lunch at home, if he is not travelling or attending lunch meetings. Lunch is served on the round marble-top table and can be surprisingly simple. It can even consist of a homemade soup and some pizza and French fries sourced from an eatery opposite his house.

Ratan too takes care of Rajen's every need, or rather, pampers him. When Rajen expressed a desire to have a fishing rod, Ratan went out of his way, going to the market himself and purchasing one on a trip to Mauritius. Rajen is, however, yet to haul a fish out from the waters adjoining the lawn.

At home is also Ratan's other loyal help called Konar Subbiah. He is from Tamil Nadu and has been with Ratan for several years. He takes care of many of Ratan's needs. The sportier of the two, he can be seen fleeting around the house attending to Ratan's smallest needs.

Treating people well is an integral part of Ratan's personality. The manner in which he treated Uday Kumar, a dog trainer with TELCO's security department who brought him his most favourite dog from Jamshedpur, still does the rounds in Tata Steel.